

HUM 2020 — Four-Week Study Plan

Dhanesh | UCF Summer 2026

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HUM 2020 — Four-Week Study Plan

Student: Dhanesh

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Instructor: Brooke Rudow

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[!] **Before every session:** All annotations, discussion posts, and exam answers must be written in your own words. GenAI is prohibited for submitted work in HUM 2020. This plan is for personal study only.

How to Use This Plan

Each week follows Dhanesh’s four-step study sequence. Don’t skip steps or jump ahead to the revision summary.

Step 1 → Read primary sources first

Step 2 → Go through the internet resources listed

Step 3 → Write your own notes (key points in your own words)

Step 4 → Do the practice questions to test yourself

Each day has a realistic time estimate. The goal is genuine understanding, not speed.

Week 1 — Greeks and the Sea

Core idea: Greece is a country shaped by the sea. No point on the mainland is more than 80 km from the coast. That geographic fact drives everything — their economy, their military power, their myths, their drama. Understanding this unlocks why Homer, Poseidon, and Greek tragedy all return to the ocean again and again.

Cross-domain connection (for Dhanesh): Think of the sea like a power grid. The Greeks who controlled the sea controlled trade routes the way a utility company controls infrastructure — whoever owned the lines, owned the network. Athens' trireme fleet was their transmission tower.

Day 1 — Primary Sources (Step 1)

Goal: Read Homer and meet Poseidon in his own domain.

Read: - [The Odyssey — Project Gutenberg \(free\)](#) — Start with Books 1, 5, and 9. Book 5 is where Poseidon destroys Odysseus' raft. Book 9 is the Cyclops. Don't try to read all 24 books in one sitting. - [Poseidon — Theoi.com](#) — Cross-reference who Poseidon is as you read. This site pulls actual quotes from ancient texts.

Questions to sit with while reading: - Why does Poseidon hate Odysseus specifically? What did Odysseus do to earn that? - How does Homer describe the sea — is it beautiful, terrifying, or both? - What does it mean that a *god* controls the sea? What does that say about how the Greeks understood nature?

Day 2 — Internet Resources (Step 2)

Goal: Get the historical and cultural context around the primary sources.

Work through: - [The Aegean Sea and the Making of Greek Civilization](#) — Read the whole piece. Pay attention to how geography forced the Greeks outward. - [Ancient Greek Colonization and Trade — Metropolitan Museum](#) — Look at the images. What do Greek trade goods look like, and where were they going? - [Poseidon — World History Encyclopedia](#) — More reliable and detailed than Wikipedia; use this as your secondary source on the god. - [Greek Tragedy: Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides — Fiveable](#) — Read the section on Aeschylus. He wrote *The Persians* about the Battle of Salamis — a real sea battle he rowed in.

Optional (if you want to go deeper): - [Aeschylus — World History Encyclopedia](#) — Short bio; helps contextualise *The Persians*

Day 3 — Notes + Annotation Prep (Step 3)

Write your own notes from what you read on Days 1 and 2. Don't copy — write what *you* understood, in your own words. Include: - What made the sea so central to Greek life (geography, trade, military, myth) - Who Poseidon is and what role he plays in the *Odyssey* - What the Battle of Salamis was and why Aeschylus writing about it matters - 2-3 quotes from Homer or the secondary sources that stood out to you, and why

Day 4 — Practice Questions & Self-Quiz (Step 4)

Test yourself before looking at any answers.

Free quiz sites: - [Ducksters — Odyssey Quiz](#) — Multiple choice, 10 questions; good warm-up - [ProProfs — Odyssey Quiz Part 1](#) — 15 questions; covers characters and plot - [FunTrivia — Homer's The Odyssey \(10 questions\)](#) — Literature-focused, slightly harder - [Study.com — Iliad & Odyssey Quiz](#) — Worksheet-style; covers themes and characters

Self-check questions (answer out loud or in writing before checking): 1. Why did Poseidon specifically target Odysseus — what was his reason? 2. What is a trireme, and why did it matter for Athenian power? 3. What is *xenia* (guest-friendship), and why does it matter in the *Odyssey*? 4. Why is the Battle of Salamis significant in the history of Western civilisation? 5. What is *nostos*? How does the idea of homecoming shape the whole poem?

Week 1 Key Terms to Know for the Exam

Term	Meaning
Poseidon	God of the sea, earthquakes, and horses; Odysseus' enemy
Trireme	Three-banked Athenian warship; backbone of the Greek navy
Xenia	Sacred law of hospitality between host and guest
Nostos	Homecoming; the theme that drives the Odyssey
Thalassocracy	Rule through sea power — Athens' model of dominance
The Battle of Salamis (480 BCE)	Greek naval defeat of Persia; Aeschylus fought in it

Week 2 — The Middle Passage

Core idea: The Middle Passage was the ocean crossing that transported enslaved Africans to the Americas between the 16th and 19th centuries. Approximately 12 million people were shipped; 2 million died en route. The sea in this context is not a place of heroic adventure — it is a site of industrial horror. Studying it through humanities means reading the firsthand accounts and understanding how writers and artists have tried to give voice to an experience that was designed to erase identity.

Cross-domain connection: Think of the ship as a system designed to optimise throughput while minimising cost — a brutal logistics problem. But humanities asks a different question: what was it like to be inside that system? Equiano's narrative forces the reader to switch from the spreadsheet view to the first-person view. That shift is exactly what the humanities does.

Day 1 — Primary Sources (Step 1)

Goal: Read Equiano's account in full. Don't summarise it — sit with it.

Read: - [Equiano's Middle Passage account — UNCG](#) — The original excerpt from *The Interesting Narrative*. Read slowly. - [Equiano — American Yawp Reader \(annotated\)](#) — Read this version if you want annotations and context alongside the text. - [Falconbridge's Account — NC Anchor](#) — A British surgeon's account from the same trade. Compare it with Equiano's.

Questions to sit with while reading: - What is the first thing Equiano describes seeing when he arrives at the coast? - What does he mean by "astonishment soon converted into terror"? - How does Equiano describe the smell and the conditions below deck? - Falconbridge is an observer writing a report; Equiano lived it. How does the *tone* of each account differ?

Day 2 — Internet Resources (Step 2)

Goal: Build the historical context around the primary sources.

Work through: - [The Middle Passage — US National Park Service](#) — Short, authoritative overview; good starting frame - [Transatlantic Slave Trade — Equal Justice Initiative](#) — More detailed; includes scale, routes, and the abolition movement - [The Middle Passage — Gilder Lehrman Institute](#) — Spotlights a specific 1749 primary source with context - [DPLA Primary Source Set — Transatlantic Slave Trade](#) — Visual and documentary primary sources; look at the images carefully

Optional: - [Equiano — World History Encyclopedia](#) — Scholarly summary with context; use if you want more depth on Equiano's life

Day 3 — Notes + Annotation Prep (Step 3)

Write your own notes. Include: - What the Triangular Trade was and how the Middle Passage fit within it - What conditions were like aboard the ships (from Equiano and Falconbridge) - Why Equiano's narrative was historically significant (abolitionism, the slave narrative genre) - A quote from Equiano that you find striking, and

your honest response to it - The difference between Equiano's account and Falconbridge's — same event, different positions

Day 4 — Practice Questions & Self-Quiz (Step 4)

Free quiz sites: - [Quizlet — The Middle Passage Flashcards](#) — Flashcard set covering key facts - [Quizlet — Slave Trade, Triangular Trade, Middle Passage, and Equiano](#) — Broader set covering all three - [Study.com — Slaves in the Middle Passage Quiz](#) — Multiple choice questions; covers conditions and history - [Smithsonian — Equiano Study Guide \(PDF\)](#) — Contains comprehension questions on the Equiano text; work through the questions at the end

Self-check questions: 1. What does “Middle Passage” refer to specifically — why is it the “middle”? 2. What did Equiano think was going to happen to him when he first boarded the ship? 3. What was the Triangular Trade, and what went in each direction? 4. Why is Equiano's narrative considered the founding text of the slave narrative genre? 5. How did the conditions Falconbridge describes as a surgeon differ from what Equiano experienced personally?

Week 2 Key Terms to Know for the Exam

Term	Meaning
Triangular Trade	Three-leg commercial system: Europe → Africa → Americas → Europe
Middle Passage	The Atlantic crossing from West Africa to the Americas
Olaudah Equiano	Formerly enslaved author; wrote the definitive Middle Passage account (1789)
Slave narrative	Literary genre established by Equiano; first-person accounts by formerly enslaved people
Abolitionism	The movement to end the slave trade; Equiano's narrative was key to it
12 million / 2 million	~12 million people shipped; ~2 million died on the crossing

Week 3 — Sea Shanties, Stories, and Selkies

Core idea: Two very different kinds of oral culture meet this week — sea shanties (working songs created by sailors) and selkie myths (shapeshifting seal-folk from Celtic and Norse folklore). What links them is that both traditions came from communities living beside and depending on the sea. Both are also oral traditions — passed person to person, mouth to ear, not written down first.

Cross-domain connection: A sea shanty is basically a clock signal in a distributed system. The shantyman's call is the clock pulse; the crew's chorus is the synchronised response. Without it, you get race conditions — sailors pulling at different times, tasks failing. Music was the protocol that made coordinated physical labour work. (EE students will recognise this immediately.)

Day 1 — Primary Sources (Step 1)

Goal: Listen to and read actual shanties; read an actual selkie story.

Do: - Search YouTube for: “**Wellerman (original)**”, “**Drunken Sailor**”, “**Haul Away Joe**” — listen with the lyrics in front of you. Notice the call-and-response structure. - **Traditional Scottish Selkie Stories — Scotland's Stories** — Read at least two of the traditional selkie tales here - **Selkies: Irish Folklore, Myths & Legends — Wilderness Ireland** — Read the selkie wife story. Pay attention to who has power and who doesn't.

Questions to sit with: - What *task* are the sailors doing in each shanty? How does the rhythm match the work? - In the selkie wife story — why does stealing her skin trap her? What does the skin represent? - Are these myths about the sea, or is the sea just the setting for stories about something else?

Day 2 — Internet Resources (Step 2)

Goal: Get the historical and cultural context for both traditions.

Work through: - **Sea Shanties — Royal Museums Greenwich** — The best single overview; covers types, history, and cultural origins - **A Deep Dive Into Sea**

Shanties — Library of Congress — Goes into African American connections and musical roots; essential context - **Shanty — Britannica** — Short and precise; covers the three main types (halyard, capstan, pumping) - **Selkie — Wikipedia** — Solid geographic and narrative overview - **Selkies: The Seal People — Daniel Kirkpatrick** — Good analysis of what the myths mean culturally and for gender

Optional: - **Selkies, Sex, and the Supernatural — The Bottle Imp** — Literary analysis of selkie mythology; useful for discussion posts on the topic

Day 3 — Notes + Annotation Prep (Step 3)

Write your own notes. Include: - What a sea shanty was *for* — the practical function, and why it mattered aboard ship - The three types of shanties and what task each matched - Where shanties came from (African American work songs, British ballads, vaudeville) - What a selkie is and where the tradition comes from (Celtic/Norse origins) - The selkie wife motif: what happens, and what it might *mean* as a metaphor - Why both traditions disappeared or changed (steam power killed shanties; modernisation disrupted oral culture)

Day 4 — Practice Questions & Self-Quiz (Step 4)

Free quiz sites: - **FunTrivia — Sailors' Songs and Sea Shanties** — 10 music trivia questions on shanties - **The Journal — Sea Shanties Quiz** — Short general knowledge quiz on shanties - **Sporcle — Sea Shanty Fill-in-the-Blank** — Fun active recall exercise - **FunTrivia — Mythology & Legends (Folklore section)** — 185+ folklore questions; filter for Celtic/Norse mythology

Watch (for selkies): - **Song of the Sea** (2014) — if you haven't seen it, watch even just the first 20 minutes; it shows the selkie tradition beautifully

Self-check questions: 1. What is a shantyman and what was his role aboard ship? 2. Name the three types of sea shanties and the specific task each was used for. 3. What happened to sea shanties when steam-powered ships replaced sailing ships? 4. What are selkies, and what region of the world did the tradition come from? 5. In the selkie wife story, why can't the selkie just leave? What keeps her trapped? 6. What does the Library of Congress article say about African American contributions to the shanty tradition?

Week 3 Key Terms to Know for the Exam

Term	Meaning
Shantyman	Lead singer of a sea shanty; improvised verses while crew sang the chorus
Call and response	Musical structure: one voice leads, group responds — the core of a shanty
Halyard shanty	Shanty for hauling ropes — slower, heavier work
Capstan shanty	Shanty for winding the capstan (anchor chain) — rhythmic circular motion
Selkie	Shapeshifting seal-human creature from Celtic/Norse oral tradition
Selkie wife motif	Man steals selkie's seal skin → she's trapped → eventually returns to the sea
Oral tradition	Culture transmitted by word of mouth, not writing

Week 4 — Literature and the Sea

Core idea: This week looks at how writers have used the ocean as more than just a setting. In great maritime literature, the sea is an active force — it shapes characters, drives plots, and carries symbolic weight. The key question is: what does the ocean *mean* to different writers, and why?

Cross-domain connection: A novelist using the sea as a symbol is doing something like an engineer using an analogy model — they're not describing the ocean literally, they're using its properties (vastness, depth, unpredictability, indifference) to say something about human experience that would be harder to say directly. Melville's white whale is not just a whale. It's a circuit that does something unexpected every time you think you've figured out how it works.

Day 1 — Primary Sources (Step 1)

Goal: Read opening sections of the key texts. You don't need to finish them — get the voice and the ocean.

Read: - [Moby-Dick, Chapters 1-3 — Project Gutenberg](#) — “Call me Ishmael.” The opening. Notice how Melville describes the sea before any action happens. - [Heart of Darkness, Part 1 — Project Gutenberg](#) — The opening river scene. Conrad sets up the sea/river as a route into darkness. - Optionally: find *The Old Man and the Sea* in your library — even the first 10 pages show Hemingway's stripped-back approach to the ocean.

Questions to sit with: - How does Ishmael describe his relationship to the sea at the start? Is it attraction, compulsion, something else? - Conrad's narrator describes the Thames river as having “known darkness” — what does he mean? - How does each author's prose style reflect the quality of the sea they're describing?

Day 2 — Internet Resources (Step 2)

Goal: Get the scholarly and analytical context.

Work through: - [Oceans of Meaning: A Blue Humanities Reading of Moby-Dick — ResearchGate](#) — Read the abstract and introduction at minimum; this is the most current academic take - [Nautical Fiction — Wikipedia](#) — Overview of the genre from Homer to Patrick O'Brian; helps you place individual books in a tradition - [Symbolism in Moby Dick — Academia.edu](#) — Useful breakdown of what the whale, the sea, and the ship each represent - [The Sea Tale in American Literature — USNI](#) — Older piece (1927) but gives the full arc of how the sea shaped American literary identity

Optional: - [Toward a Blue Cultural Studies — Steve Mentz \(PDF\)](#) — Dense academic essay but foundational for the field; read the introduction and conclusion

Day 3 — Notes + Annotation Prep (Step 3)

Write your own notes. Include: - What “Blue Humanities” means as a field and why it matters for reading these texts - How Melville uses the whale and the sea as symbols — and what those symbols could mean - How Conrad uses the ocean/river

differently from Melville - The concept of the sea as “unknowable” — what does that mean for both authors? - At least one quote from Moby-Dick and what you think it means

Day 4 — Practice Questions & Self-Quiz (Step 4)

Free quiz sites: - [SparkNotes — Moby-Dick Full Book Quiz](#) — 25 multiple choice questions; solid exam prep - [LitCharts — Moby-Dick Quizzes](#) — Chapter-by-chapter quizzes; good for targeted review - [CliffsNotes — Moby-Dick Quiz](#) — Short quiz with explanations - [GradeSaver — Moby Dick Quiz 1](#) — 15 questions on the first part of the novel - [BookRags — Free Moby-Dick Quiz](#) — 25 multiple choice; broad coverage - [Quizlet — Moby Dick Practice Quizzes](#) — Flashcard format

Self-check questions: 1. Who is Ishmael, and why does he go to sea at the start of Moby-Dick? 2. What does the white whale represent? Give at least two possible readings. 3. What is Captain Ahab’s motivation — and what does his obsession say about humans and nature? 4. How does Conrad’s use of the river in *Heart of Darkness* parallel Melville’s use of the ocean? 5. What does “Blue Humanities” mean, and how does it change how we read maritime literature? 6. Name three major maritime authors covered in the course and one key theme from each.

Week 4 Key Terms to Know for the Exam

Term	Meaning
Blue Humanities	Field that centres oceans in cultural, historical, and ecological study
Ecocriticism	Reading literature through the lens of its relationship to the natural world
Moby Dick (the whale)	Symbol of the unknowable, of nature’s indifference, of obsession
Captain Ahab	Protagonist of Moby-Dick; his obsession drives the novel toward destruction
Ishmael	The narrator of Moby-Dick; survivor and witness

Term	Meaning
Maritime novel	Genre using the sea as primary setting to explore human nature
Conrad's darkness	The river/ocean as a route into moral and colonial darkness (<i>Heart of Darkness</i>)

Weeks 5+ — Hawaii, Surfing, and Nature Sports

Note: The full schedule from Week 6 onward isn't visible in the extracted syllabus. Check Webcourses for the complete topic list and update this plan accordingly.

Core idea: Surfing in Hawai'i — he'e nalu — is at least 1,500 years old. It was never just a sport. It was tied to social rank, spirituality, and a deep technical knowledge of the ocean. Colonisation suppressed it. The 20th century commercialised it. Today, Hawaiian surfers are actively reclaiming it as an expression of indigenous identity and resistance.

Cross-domain connection (for Dhanesh): Traditional Polynesian navigation — finding your position by stars, swells, birds, and wind — is a multi-sensor fusion problem. No GPS; no instruments. Just environmental data, pattern recognition, and a mental model built over generations. Sound like any signal processing concepts you've seen?

Day 1 — Primary Sources & Cultural Voices (Step 1)

Read/Watch: - [Hōkūle'a — Polynesian Wayfinding](#) — Read the Hōkūle'a project's own account of traditional navigation and what it means for Hawaiian identity - [Guiding Us Home: Hawaiian Wayfinding — Smithsonian Folklife](#) — Longer read; gives the full story of the 1975 launch and the Hawaiian Renaissance - [The Kuleana Way: Surfing as Indigenous Hawaiian Resistance](#) — More recent essay on what surfing means culturally today - [Duke Kahanamoku: Hawaii History & Surfing — PBS American Masters](#) — Kahanamoku brought surfing to the world; understanding him is key to understanding how the culture spread

Questions to sit with: - What did surfing mean to Hawaiians before European contact? How is that different from how we think of it today? - Who could surf, and who couldn't? What determined your access? - What did European missionaries do to surfing, and why?

Day 2 — Internet Resources (Step 2)

Work through: - [The Complicated History of Colonialism in Surfing — PBS SoCal](#) — Best single piece on colonialism and surfing - [Surfing in Early 20th-Century Hawai'i — ResearchGate](#) — Academic paper on appropriation; read the abstract and key sections - [Polynesian Navigation & Settlement of the Pacific — World History Encyclopedia](#) — The full story of how Polynesians got to Hawai'i in the first place - [He'e Nalu: Surfing in Ancient Hawai'i — Surf Club Maui](#) — Accessible overview of the tradition before contact - [How Ancient Polynesians Conquered the Pacific — Fair Observer](#) — Connects wayfinding and surfing as parallel ocean skills

Day 3 — Notes + Annotation Prep (Step 3)

Write your own notes. Include: - What he'e nalu meant in traditional Hawaiian society — the spiritual and social dimensions - How social rank affected who could surf and on what kind of board - What colonisation did to the practice and how - What the Hōkūle'a project is and why it matters as cultural reclamation - What kuleana means and how it connects to the revival movement

Day 4 — Practice Questions & Self-Quiz (Step 4)

Resources for practice: - [History of Surfing — Iguana Surf \(overview with key facts\)](#) — Read and create your own flashcards from the facts - [Polynesian Navigation — University of Hawai'i at Mānoa](#) — University-level resource; has in-built review concepts

Self-check questions: 1. What does he'e nalu literally mean in English? 2. How did social rank (ali'i vs. maka'āinana) affect surfing in traditional Hawaiian culture? 3. What did European missionaries do to surfing and why? 4. What is the Hōkūle'a,

when was it launched, and what was its cultural significance? 5. What is kuleana, and how is it used in discussions of indigenous cultural reclamation? 6. How did Polynesian navigators find their way across the open Pacific without instruments?

Week 5 Key Terms to Know for the Exam

Term	Meaning
He'e nalu	Hawaiian term for surfing; literally "wave sliding"
Ali'i	Hawaiian nobility; had the best boards and exclusive surfing areas
Maka'āinana	Common people; had more limited surfing access
Hōkūle'a	Traditional Hawaiian voyaging canoe; launched 1975; led the Hawaiian Renaissance
Hawaiian Renaissance (1970s)	Cultural revival reclaiming surfing, wayfinding, hula, and language
Kuleana	Hawaiian concept of rights and responsibilities; used in indigenous reclamation
Wayfinding	Polynesian navigation using stars, swells, birds, and wind — no instruments

General Practice & Revision Resources

These work for any week:

Resource	Use It For
SparkNotes	Summaries and quizzes on literary texts
LitCharts	Theme analysis and chapter quizzes
Quizlet	Search any topic — flashcard sets exist for everything in this course

Resource	Use It For
Study.com	Short quiz-and-worksheet format; good for timed practice
FunTrivia — Humanities	Broader humanities trivia; good for recall practice
World History Encyclopedia	Reliable secondary source for any historical topic
Britannica	Encyclopaedia-level check on any key term

Session End Checklist

At the end of each study session, ask yourself:

- ☐ Which step am I on (primary sources / internet resources / notes / practice questions)?
- ☐ Did I write notes in my own words — not copied from the source?
- ☐ Did I try the practice questions *before* looking at answers?
- ☐ What's the one thing I most need to revisit next session?
- ☐ Is there anything I want to raise as a question or annotation point?

Reminder: Anything you submit — annotations, discussion posts, exam answers — must be in your own words. GenAI is prohibited for submitted work in HUM 2020.

Built for Dhanesh's personal study. Not for submission. All coursework must be independently written.